Centre to ensure that procurement and adequate supply of vaccines were made.

Finally, on 7 June, in an address to the nation, the prime minister announced that the Centre would take over the vaccination drive including vaccine procurement. The Centre, he announced, would also provide free vaccines to all those over the age of 18 in government-run vaccination centres. The Centre would buy 75 per cent of the vaccines, leaving 25 per cent for the private sector to purchase, which could then run paid vaccination drives at capped rates. Elaborating the sorry state of dependency and desperation which India faced in the past, the prime minister remarked, 'If you look at the history of vaccinations in India… you will see that India would have to wait decades for procuring vaccines from abroad. When vaccination programmes ended in other countries, it wouldn't have even begun in our country.'[46]

Vaccine nationalism is in the negative interest of the world and is entirely discreditable behaviour. However, this has been the norm for a long time. India, in the past, has been at the receiving end of the problem, having had to suffer for much longer periods of time and typically live with the diseases until vaccines would reach us, in some cases after over a decade. Taking a closer look, the rotavirus vaccines, while available to the world in 1998, reached India only in 2015. The Japanese encephalitis vaccine reached us in 2013 as compared to 1930, when it became available to wealthier countries. The Hepatitis B vaccine, which became available for the world in 1982, arrived in India for use only in 2002. While the world got the polio vaccine in 1955, it became available to India 22 years later, in 1978, after which we were able to become polio-free only in 2014. Even the tetanus vaccine took 54 years after the rest of the world to come to India for mass inoculation. The problem this time around was the behavioural pattern of the virus and its impact on entire countries due to high transmission rates because of which accessing enough doses for our population in the least possible time became absolutely crucial. Here is a shuddering thought: up until now, India used to be part of the developing world which wouldn't have access to vaccines for multiple years after the wealthier nations have inoculated their populations many times over and wasted millions of unused, over-ordered doses.

However, with the constant attacks back home, India was compelled to temporarily suspend the Vaccine Maitri initiative. Vaccine Maitri had not